The Girls Who Went Away

By Ann Fessler

ANNIE: **(Pg 36-37)** Mother, we didn't go to the circus last night. We went to a doctor.

MOTHER: Oh my God, don't tell me you're pregnant!

ANNIE: Within a few days, she took me to her doctor . . .

DOCTOR: There's a place where they send girls like her in Kansas City. It's pretty expensive. If you have any money put aside for her, use it for this. She doesn't deserve to have it anyway.

MOM: *(to Annie)* . . . and you're going to stay there until you have the baby. Then you're going to give your baby up for adoption and you're going to come home and forget that this ***ever*** happened. Someday you'll thank me.

ANNIE: That was when the shame began. At sixteen, I had to do everything that my mother said. That was it. There were no options. It was all decided for me.

FESSLER: **(Pg 20-21)** Just about everyone who lived through [the 1950s-1960s] has a memory of a girl from their high school, college, or neighborhood who ***disappeared***. The girls who went away were told by family members, social-service agencies, and clergy that relinquishing their child for adoption was the ***only*** acceptable option. It would preserve their reputation and save both mother and child from a lifetime of shame. They must surrender their child, keep their secret, move on, and forget. *(beat)* Between the end of World War II in 1945 and the passage of *Roe v. Wade in 1973*, one and a half million babies were relinquished for nonfamily adoptions.

INTRODUCTION

Margaret Atwood wrote in The Handmaid's Tale: "But who can remember pain, once it's over? All that remains of it is a shadow, not in the mind even, in the flesh. Pain marks you, but too deep to see. Out of sight, out of mind."

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FESSLER: (Pg 19) Despite the increase in the number of young people having sex in the 1950s and 1960s, access to birth control and sex education lagged far behind. Fearing that sex education would promote or encourage sexual relations, parents and schools thought it best to leave young people uninformed.

NANCY: (Pg 55) . . . *(to mother)* How do they get rid of the mark when they take the baby out?" She stood there, three feet from me, with a look of horror on her face and said.

MOM: My God, Nancy, that baby comes out the same way it went in.

NANCY: I was sixteen and pregnant and I did not know how babies were born. It's pathetic, but it's true. I mean, it's borderline child abuse not to share this kind of information. How can anyone think that we will just absorb it naturally, or that it's our responsibility as children to figure it out?

FESSLER: (Pg 39) By 1973 the percentage of unmarried girls who had gone "all the way" before they were 20 years old had risen to 68%. **(Pg 20)** The result was an explosion in premarital pregnancy and in the numbers of babies surrendered for adoption.

DIANE: (Pg 43) Girls are only two types, a Madonna or a whore, and not the singer Madonna, the virgin Madonna. You were good or bad. You were very bad if you had sex. So, you couldn't really ***plan*** to have sex; it had to just ***happen***.

CLAUDIA: (Pg 64) I don't remember any dialogue around having choices. *(mimicking those in charge)* You are gonna do the only thing that is right. You're gonna give that baby to good people, decent people, people who can take care of it because you are so bad and so flawed for just having this happen. *(pause as a memory surfaces)* **(Pg 67)** I named my baby Raina Elizabeth [and] I did get to hold her for three days. She had a little tiny heart-shaped mouth, big dark eyes, beautiful skin, and tons and tons of black hair. *(pause)* And then on the third day my parents came. It was the beginning of it being invisible. ***It*** was never, ever, brought up again. ***It*** was never talked about—not once, not ever.

GLORY: (Pg 72) I called my folks from college to tell them I was pregnant and my dad said . . . "Don't come home." At the time, my dad was a sheriff. He would be up for

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reelection and he did not want a daughter like me around. It was fine while I was class valedictorian and the shining star, but not while I was pregnant, no.

FESSLER: **(Pg 75)** In one of the strictest forms of banishment, high schools and most colleges required a pregnant girl to withdraw immediately. It was not until Title IX of the Education Amendments Act of 1972 that federally funded high schools and colleges, by law, could not expel a pregnant girl or a teenage mother.

MARGARET: I got called down to the office and the principal said . . .

PRINCIPAL: There's a lot of gossip about you being pregnant. We figure that you're about three to four months and you may not return to school until you have a doctor's note saying that you're not pregnant.

MARGARET: The gym teacher helped me clean out my locker and drove me home, and the school called my mother. I had been this girl who didn't smoke, didn't drink, didn't do anything wrong. Everybody's parents wanted their daughters to be with me. Now, when I walked down the street, parents made their daughters cross the street.

FESSLER: **(Pg 77)** Meanwhile, the young men who had fathered these children largely escaped social condemnation. Their role in the pregnancy wasn't publicly visible, so they were not expelled from school, and were generally not treated with scorn, and not considered a disgrace to their families. Most parents supported the double standard by holding their daughters, but not their sons, accountable. **(Pg 78)** The standards of the day dictated that a young woman was responsible for stopping the advances of a young man. She was ultimately responsible both for ***his*** behavior and it was "her own fault" if she got pregnant.

YVONNE: **(Pg 89)** My dad said . . .

DAD: I'm not going to spend one damn cent on that little bastard.

YVONNE: **(Pg 92)** What's worse -- for a child to grow up being adopted or being labeled illegitimate? What's going to be harder for him to live with? **(Pg 98)** From everything I see, I think the general public believes that mothers who give their babies away are glad to be rid of them, they're glad to be rid of the problem. They think, "She didn't

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care about that kid. She just wanted him out of the way so that she could go on having a good time." I've heard people say that. It's like if you have a child and you're not married, you don't have those same maternal feelings that other mothers have? I have never, ever met a mother who felt that way. Never.

MARY: **(Pg 102)** I told my mother and she started screaming at me. It was horrific. I was told to leave the house and not return. I was not allowed to make a phone call -- not allowed to take any clothes, pack a suitcase, nothing. I don't remember where I went to use a phone, but I called the doctor I had babysat for and I went to their house. He pleaded with my mother and father to let me come home. But they refused to take me back.

POLLIE: **(Pg 103)** My mother was horrified. She called me a slut, a whore. And it seemed like just a day or so after that, my mother came in and had me go to the bathroom, disrobe, and get into the bathtub, which was very humiliating in itself. She administered a douche, which was very painful. I didn't know anything about a douche. I found out later that what she had used was Lysol from the brown bottle. . .

LYNNE: **(Pg 132)** We drove to the maternity home on back roads. I walked in and there were all of these strange pregnant people and these nuns. And some of the nuns were harsh. Harsh. I had committed a sin. It's not like today when you go through therapy, for God's sakes. No. There was no therapy.

DEBORAH: **(Pg 133)** I found the letters I wrote [to my parents] while I was ***away***. They are hard to read because I was still so naïve. I was trying to protect them, trying to give them this picture of a normal life with my continual, Shirley Temple kind of "I'm having a great day, the baby is kicking, everything is wonderful," like it was a normal thing. I mean, I was living in an institution, for Christ's sake. They locked us in at night. It wasn't normal life.

LYNNE: **(Pg 143)** I remember the nun at St. Andre's telling me that it was God's will. We were fulfilling the needs of women who couldn't have children. God chose us to bear these children for these women who couldn't have any. I was so susceptible to this

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thinking: I must accept God's will. I could have more children, you see, so what's one child to be given away? I would see this child in heaven.

KAREN: **(Pg 149)** Then they would say things about the baby. It's always "***the*** baby," never "***your*** baby."

CASEWORKER: This experience will end. You will forget that you went through this. You will get over it. You know what you did was wrong? You know that you are really not worthy of keeping your own child? That child needs a mother and a father, and the things that they can give that child. You can't provide anything that child needs.

KAREN: **(Pg 152-153)** We were not told any of ***our*** rights. We were not told we had the right to keep our own baby. The social workers should have been required to tell us what was available to us, so we could make an informed decision. We were never told anything except adoption—it was the only option offered to us. We weren't told that we could get child support from the fathers. We weren't told that we could apply for welfare or Aid to Families with Dependent Children, which was available then. There was a lack of informed consent. All of our rights were abused. Ignored and abused. The rights that people take for granted today, we were denied. We didn't know because we were young, and we trusted our parents, and we trusted authority. They would tell us what was best. So, we figured if that's what was best, then that was what we needed to do. They've injured and damaged millions of people. You're just so beaten down by being in that place and being told, "You can't, you can't, you can't." And "You ***aren't*** a mother, you don't ***deserve*** to be a mother." It was just overwhelming . . .

The whole point was to keep us scared and feeling guilt all the time. And compliant, you know? "You do this and you can go home." It makes me very, very angry today to think about that manipulation. To me, it was evil. Nobody ever said, "What do you want, Karen? Do you want to keep your baby?" *(pause to regain composure, then with anger)*

CASEWORKER: No, no, no. Don't even think of that because it's not your child. It's these

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people's child over here. It's been promised to them. You should be ***happy*** you're giving your child to someone so wonderful who has so much to offer that child. You should be ***grateful*** we're solving your problem. You made this mistake. You caused this ***problem*** for everyone.

KAREN: **(Pg 154)** There was such emotional and mental damage done. We were not criminals. We were mothers. The difference was I was not an ***authenticated*** mother. I was an illegal mother. I was a denied mother. And I had to come home and live my life as if I was an unwilling accomplice to the kidnapping of my own child. You have to live with the trauma of losing your child and then you have to live with the trauma of knowing you didn't stop it. How do you do that?

CONCLUSION

We've come a long way from 1950 -- from the lack of education; the stigma of being an unwed mother; and a woman's right to choose. But the pendulum of values began shifting again in 2022.

**Since the Supreme Court overturned Roe v. Wade and the federal right to abortion in 2022, there has been a nationwide expansion of maternity homes – many of them faith-based. As abortion restrictions increase, anti-abortion advocates want to open more of these transitional housing facilities, which often have long waitlists. As of 2024, there are more than 450 maternity homes in the U.S.*

You see . . . ""Nothing changes instantaneously: in a gradually heating bathtub you'd be boiled to death before you knew it." -- Margaret Atwood, the Handmaid's Tale

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AWARD HISTORY

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